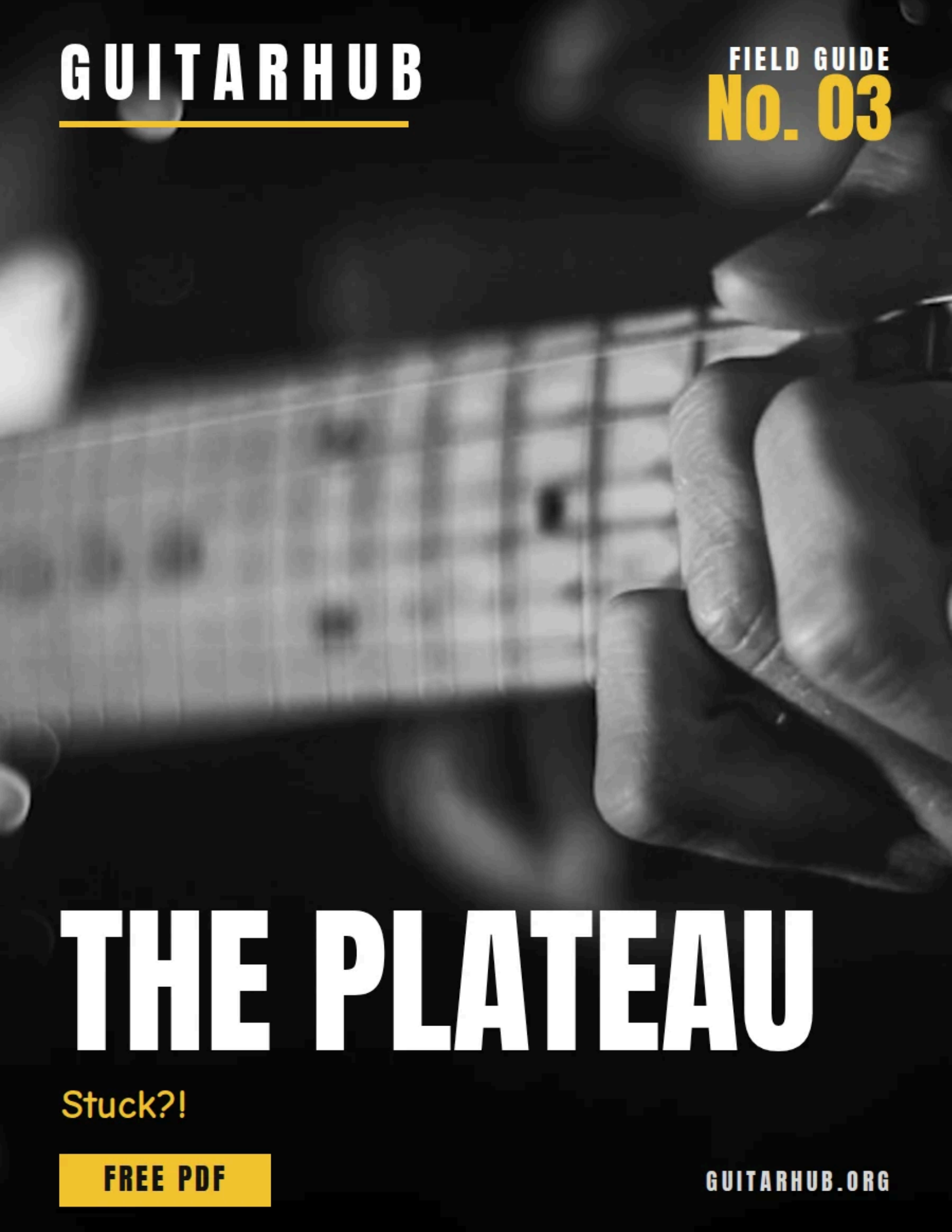




GUITARHUB

FIELD GUIDE
No. 03

THE PLATEAU

Stuck?!

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Why guitar practice plateaus, *and how to break one.*

You have played for years and the playing stopped changing. More hours will not fix that on their own. What the hours contain is the thing to change.

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Guitar practice plateaus when the difficulty of what you play stops rising while the hours keep going in. Adding time to a session that contains nothing difficult produces more of the same playing. Six causes are worth ruling out first: practicing what already sounds good, never playing at performance tempo, never hearing yourself from outside your own head, having no single target you could pass or fail, starting new material before the last piece is finished, and working around a technique problem instead of repairing it. Each one has a tell you can check in your own playing and a fix you can start this week.

This is the written account of the six causes, so you can read them and recognise your own. It does not rank them for you. The [practice plateau diagnostic](#) asks nine questions about your last few sessions, scores five blockers against their own maximums, and returns the one your answers point at hardest, which is the part a page of prose cannot do. Read here to understand the causes. Go there to find out which one is yours.

A plateau is a repetition problem, not a volume problem

The first stretch of playing improves on its own. Almost everything is new, so difficulty arrives without being scheduled: every chord shape, every strum pattern, every song is something you could not do last month. Then it stops arriving. You know enough shapes to get through most of what you attempt, and a session fills up with things you can already play at the speed you can already play them.

What improves is what is currently failing. Practice changes the playing at the edge where you can just barely hold it together, and nowhere else. A session with no failure in it maintains you at exactly the level you walked in with, which is why a plateau survives more practice. The hour was not wasted. It was spent on the part that was already finished.

Read the six statements below. Any that are true of your last three sessions are causes, not moods.

- You practiced things you can already play.
- You never reached the tempo the music is actually played at.
- You have not heard a recording of yourself in the last month.

- You cannot name one thing that would count as finished.
- You started something new before the last thing was done.
- You changed a fingering, a voicing, or an arrangement to avoid a movement you cannot make.

The six causes, the tell, and the fix

You practice what already sounds good

Comfortable playing is the default, because it is the only part of practice that sounds like music. Nobody schedules it. It happens because starting from something familiar is easier than starting from something broken, and once the guitar is out and the sound is good, stopping to work on something that sounds bad takes a decision.

The tell. Your practice sounds good from the next room. If someone walking past would think you were playing rather than working, most of the hour was maintenance.

The fix. Put one thing in the session you cannot yet do: a passage that breaks down by the third bar, a change you miss more often than you land. Ten minutes of it, first, while your hands and your attention are fresh. Keep the comfortable playing. Move it to the end, where it belongs.

You never play at performance tempo

Slow practice is correct, and it is also where plateaus hide. A passage rehearsed only well under tempo never meets the problems that appear at full speed. The picking hand stiffens. The fretting hand starts arriving late. A shift that was comfortable becomes a jump. Those are not faster versions of the slow-tempo problems. They are different problems, and they exist only above a certain speed.

The tell. You know exactly how the passage feels at your practice tempo and have no idea how it feels at the real one, because you have not tried it there in weeks.

The fix. Play it at the target tempo once at the start of every session, badly if that is what happens. The failed attempt tells you which bar is the actual problem, and it is usually one bar rather than the whole passage. Then work in steps below it and return to the top before you stop. The [tempo ladder builder](#) lays those steps out for a passage you choose.

You never hear yourself from outside

You cannot hear your own timing while you are producing it. Your ears are busy predicting what your hands are about to do, and the prediction smooths over the gaps. A recording removes the prediction.

The first one is unpleasant. It is also the most information you will get all week: a transition that rushes, a chord that never fully rings, a fill landing half a beat late, dynamics that sit flat from the first bar to the last. None of that is audible from behind the guitar.

The tell. You describe your sessions in feelings. Good days and bad days, rather than a specific thing that got better.

The fix. Record one take a week on your phone. One attempt, no edit, no second try. Listen once and write down the first thing that is wrong. That becomes the difficult ten minutes of the next session. The recording matters less than the comparison: a take from four weeks ago is the only honest evidence that anything changed.

You have no single target you could pass or fail

“Get better at soloing” cannot be finished, so it cannot be practiced. It has no end and no test, which makes every session equally defensible and none of them aimed. A target that works is one a stranger could score. “Play the intro at full tempo, twice through, no stops, no buzzes” is a target. “Improve my rhythm” is a subject heading.

That is the whole difference between deliberate practice and playing something again. The first has a standard it can fail.

The tell. Asked what you are working on, you name a subject rather than a passage. Scales. Timing. Theory. Speed.

The fix. Write one sentence containing a specific piece of music, a specific tempo, and a specific standard for clean, with a date on it four weeks out. One sentence, not five.

You start new material before the last piece is finished

Beginning is the enjoyable part. The first days on a new song produce visible progress every time you sit down, because everything in it is new. The end of a piece is the opposite: slow, unglamorous, four bars that still fall apart while the rest is fine. There is always another song more interesting than those four bars.

A shelf of nearly finished pieces feels like a repertoire and behaves like nothing. Under any pressure, a room, a camera, another player, the unfinished parts are precisely what breaks, because they were never taken past the point where they hold.

The tell. You can start twenty songs and play none of them all the way through at tempo.

The fix. Finish one. Pick the closest to done, decide in advance what finished means, and start nothing new until it holds. The song readiness score checks a song against the parts that break under pressure, which is usually not the part you have been practicing.

You worked around a technique problem instead of repairing it

Every guitarist carries some technique debt. The barre that never rings, so you play the three-string version. The pinky you stopped using early and never brought back. The alternate picking that turns into all downstrokes once the tempo rises. The shift you avoid by choosing another position. Each substitution was reasonable at the time, and each one let you keep playing.

The debt stays invisible while the workaround holds. It becomes visible when a piece requires the thing you routed around, and by then it is not one piece. It is a category of music you quietly stopped attempting.

The tell. There are songs you decided you do not like, and they happen to require the same movement.

The fix. Name the movement and practice it away from any song, a few minutes at the start of the session. The barre on its own. The pinky on its own. Isolated technique is dull, and it is the only way the debt gets paid. Chord changes respond particularly well to isolation, and the Strumly guide to [smoother chord transitions](#) takes one change apart.

Change one thing, not six

Six causes is a diagnosis, not a task list. Rebuilding an entire routine in a week fails the way a crash diet fails: none of it survives a bad Tuesday. Pick the cause whose tell was most obviously true, and change one thing about how the session runs.

1. Record a baseline take before you change anything. One attempt, at the tempo you can currently manage.
2. Choose the single cause whose tell you recognized fastest. The fast recognition is usually the honest one.
3. Change one thing about the session, and write the change down so you cannot renegotiate it midweek.
4. Run the changed session for a week without adjusting it again.
5. Record the same take at the end of the week and listen to the two back to back.

If the two recordings sound the same, the change was the wrong one or it was too small. That is worth knowing, and it took a week to find out. If you need a shape for the rest of the week around that one change, the Strumly guide to [designing a practice routine](#) covers the ordering.

How you will know the plateau broke

Not by feeling better. Feeling is the least reliable instrument in the room, and it moves with sleep, mood, and how the guitar happens to be set up that day.

The plateau broke when something you could not play a month ago is something you can play now, at tempo, on demand, with a recording at each end to prove it. That is a small claim. It is also a real one, and it repeats: a month later, on the next thing you could not do.

If more than one of the six tells was true and you cannot decide where to start, the [practice plateau diagnostic](#) asks a short set of questions and names the part of your practice that stopped producing change. It takes a couple of minutes, needs no account, and nothing leaves your browser.